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China and the lingering Pax Americana

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Accompanying the economic rise of China, many commentators have argued that the global political centre of gravity has been shifting from West to East and from developed countries to developing ones. The book by British writer Martin Jacques, *When China Rules the World*, is just an example. Roger Altman, a veteran investment banker and former Deputy Secretary of Treasury of the US, published 'The Great Crash, 2008: the geopolitical setback for the West' in *Foreign Affairs* in the wake of the global financial crisis, arguing that the financial distress of the West and the continuous robust economic performance of China are accelerating the waning of America's global power and the waxing of China's. Journalist Fareed Zakaria even titled his 2009 bestseller *The Post-American World*, seeing the rise of China at the expense of the US as a global power shift comparable to the rise of the West during the Renaissance and the rise of the US in the 20th century.

Many see China as the most powerful BRICS country, the one that has the actual capability of leading other emerging powers to topple US domination and foster a new and more egalitarian order. But unfortunately that talk about falling US global power and the rise of China as a new superpower leading humanity out of Pax Americana is greatly exaggerated, just as talk of the rise of Germany and Japan as challengers to the US back in the 1970s and 1980s was exaggerated. The decline of US dominance in world politics, while true, has been slowed and delayed. US share of global GDP has been stable above 20% and it continues to be the world's largest economy with a comfortable lead, as measured in current US dollars. The US also continues to be the world's leading military power, with all other military powers trailing far behind.